



Kamal Nath's remark that the years under Vajpayee were "a great learning experience", led to a comment that those "under Manmohan were a great earning experience", a dig at Baalu.

the "hurly burly of 100 days" made a frontal assault on the senses of Parliament.

What kept the political flock together was the Home Ministry's move to cut down VIP security—based on a reduced threat perception—of leaders like Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati and SP President Mulayam Singh Yadav. The Government, sensing trouble, as the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha witnessed unruly scenes, soon backed off and the netas got back their human shields. In the railway budget, as West Bengal bagged much of the concessions, minister Mamata Banerjee paused to give Bodo MP S. Bwiswmuthiary on-the-spot concession—"I will give you one (train)!" Taking

lessons from earlier experiences, much of these concessions hardly materialise. And SP's Reoti Raman Singh summarised it with a single response to the speech, "*Kab tak* (When will the offer be realised)?"

The new season at the Lok Sabha that saw the harvest of young MPs, brought in a line up of fresh faces. But the participation of youngsters was minimal in the session. Only 8 per cent of them participated in debates while their participation in total proceedings just notched up 10 per cent. Maybe their surnames helped them find their way to Parliament, but that didn't ensure their worry lines and youthful voices were on full display. All they did was raising varied questions—Dushyant Singh on ceramic products and Naveen Jindal on exports from SEZs—and ended up receiving bumper-sticker answers from the ministers concerned. Jyoti Mirdha, Meenakshi Natarajan and P.K. Biju came in as top debaters among the first-timers; Jhansi Botcha Lakshmi emerged as number one by far among women MPs by taking part in discussions ranging from the Finance Bill to the drought situation.

Many blame it on the refusal of the political parties to indulge youngsters and women in debates. While BJP MPs managed 34 per cent of the total time young MPs participated, for the Congress—with a star-studded line up of studio-hopping MPs—the number was just 13 per cent. It finished even behind the SP's young MPs who availed 15 per cent of the time. The session saw the emergence of Sharad Yadav of the Janata Dal(U)—animated and quirky—taking up much of the Opposition space with intervening in almost all issues. The CPI(M) lost its ground, with a participation in just 4 per cent of the debates. The BJP may be riven by factional feuds but its two deputy leaders Sushma Swaraj and S.S. Ahluwalia displayed sartorial symphony—Ahluwalia's blue turban and Swaraj's blue sari in perfectly matched shades. One could blame it on telepathy, but nothing could match open competition within the BJP leadership. While Swaraj and Arun Jaitley continued their shadow war, Jaswant Singh, Yashwant Sinha and Arun Shourie sulked during

Jammed Session

The first Lok Sabha meet was a graveyard of key legislations

■ The dearth of legal framework and financial provisions was forgotten in the hurry to announce 100-day projects.

■ The Government deferred the Judges Bill amid heavy criticism from both the Left and Right.

■ The Land Acquisition Bill has been put on the backburner after Mamata turned red.

■ The CPI(M) lost its ground with a participation in just 4 per cent of the debates.

■ BJP MPs clocked 34 per cent of the total time young MPs participated, the Congress got a paltry 13 per cent.